

My arguments did not appear to make very much of an impression. I strongly suspect the jittery businessman went away thinking that at best I had been contaminated by ex-posure to a subversive alien ideology and at worst had turned into one of those parlor pinks he'd heard so much about. Quite plainly, the man is one of the unfortunately far-too-numerous Americans who seem to have lost their perspective and sense of humor and fair play in recent years. They've developed a tendency to automatically equate dissension with disloyalty. They view any criticism of our existing social, economic and political forms as sedition and subversion.

Now, I am most certainly neither parlor nor any other shade of pink. It hardly seems necessary for me, of all people, to say that I'm vigorously opposed to government ownership of industry, that I'm an energetic exponent of the free-enterprise system. I can't imagine myself comfortable under a Socialist regime. Nor can I imagine such a regime looking upon me with much tolerance.

The political implications of the anecdote I've cited are purely incidental and coincidental. I used it solely to illustrate a manifestation of what I, for one, have observed to be a contemporary American phenomenon and which, to my mind, is disturbing, deplorable and truly dangerous. I'm referring to the growing reluctance of Americans to criticize, and their increasing tendency to condemn those

152

who, in ever dwindling numbers, will still voice dissent, dissatisfaction and criticism.

Let me make it quite clear that I hold no special brief for any particular ideology, party, group or school of thought which might want or seek to bring about changes of any kind in our manners, mores or institutions. I am not a reformer, crusader, social philosopher, political or economic theorist. I do, however, consider myself enough of a realist to appreciate that this is not—and never has been and never will be—the best of all possible worlds. The concept that any *status quo* is perfect and permanent, that one must under no circumstances raise questions, voice doubts or seek improvements can only produce complacency, then stagnation and finally collapse. It does